

STARS AND GRIPES

THE KEY ISSUES

PAKISTAN Not putting enough pressure on it to act against terror groups. Now, the US is rewarding Pakistan with military packages.

AFGHANISTAN US-led strategy to co-opt the Taliban is being implemented. India fears that the Taliban may use it to regroup and the ISI will use it to foment terrorism.

26/11 INVESTIGATIONS A plea bargain and a likely lenient sentence for Headley raises doubts about US sincerity.

ENTITY LIST Indian Government companies still on a US sanctions list which is impeding trust.

CLIMATE CHANGE US wants India to reduce emissions.

HOW TO FIX THEM

PAKISTAN Sustained pressure is required. Should ensure that any package to the country should be linked to its action against terror groups targeting India.

AFGHANISTAN Should coordinate their positions better. Must train the Afghan National Army and work on a UN-led transition plan for Kabul.

26/11 INVESTIGATIONS Extraditing Headley will be a huge step that will bridge the trust deficit in the US.

ENTITY LIST The fears about the US as a reliable partner can be allayed by pruning the Entity List.

CLIMATE CHANGE Provide incentives for reducing emissions.

in mediating with the Taliban which will directly hit Indian security interests. Giving legitimacy to the Taliban will only turn Afghanistan into a safe haven for terror groups to target India. Another irritant is Washington's continued sanctions regime in the form of the Entity List. Says Rao: "We look forward to the removal of remaining Indian organisations from the Entity List. It is anomalous that a body like Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), which is developing several collaborations with NASA, should continue to be on this list." Even though India is considered a strategic partner, currently 14 Indian government companies, including those affiliated to the ISRO, Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Department of Atomic Energy, are on the Entity List. The blacklist has been designed by the US to prevent these organisations



THE US FLIP FLOP ON HEADLEY HAS RAISED DOUBTS

getting any sensitive equipment or component that may be used in India's missile or nuclear weapons programme.

In the past few months, India has articulated its concerns to Washington that the strategic relationship is coming under strain. When US Defence

Secretary Robert Gates met Defence Minister A.K. Antony in January this year, he was told that while the US wanted to have a broad-based defence relationship with India, its continued military support to Pakistan and export controls on Indian entities like the ISRO and DRDO were hampering the strategic relationship. "We have articulated our concerns to the US that this does not help the strategic relationship," says Antony. For India, US space technology is critical for launch vehicles and sensors for intelligence gathering surveillance and real time imaging. However, New Delhi considers it discriminatory and believes that it goes against the spirit of the Indo-US strategic relationship. Sources say that even though China obtained satellite and missile technologies as well as telemetry systems and nose-cone technologies from US companies, the US Government has denied these corporations the permission to transfer similar technologies to India's civilian space programme.

Then there are problems on Iran, with New Delhi having told Washington that it is not in favour of sanctions on the country. India needs Iran as a strategic balance in its Afghanistan gameplan apart from a transit partner for trade in Central Asia. On Climate Change too, while India continues to support investments in green technology, it is opposed to a US suggestion of an internationally mandated and enforceable regime which New Delhi believes may be a digression from its growth agenda. Finally, there is the Nuclear Liabilities Bill that put the UPA Government on the backfoot. Sources say that the US had wanted the bill to be passed before the Prime Minister travels to Washington for the nuclear security summit in April. National Security Adviser Shiv Shankar Menon held a series of meetings with the Opposition leaders only to be rebuffed. The key question is whether the relationship can be mended. Most issues can be resolved but the danger is that if they are allowed to simmer, they could become intractable. Officials are hoping that next month, when Manmohan goes to Washington, it may provide an opportunity for both sides to step back and reevaluate the relationship before it's too late. ■



“Headley must be punished severely but we are yet to get any assurance from the US about India getting access to him.”

S.M. KRISHNA, External Affairs Minister